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Blog

Recent Oil Spills Expose Risk of Fossil Fuel Energy Strategy

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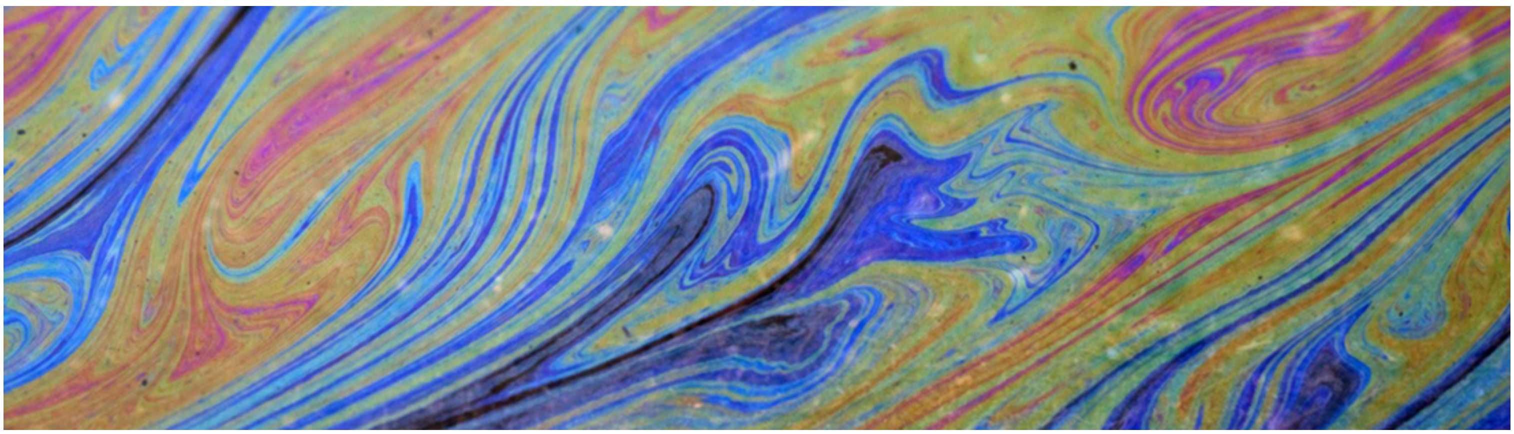

North America is in the midst of a cataclysmic rise in oil related disasters. From the constant (http://reut.rs/1EPdn9Z) oil train (http://reut.rs/1CnG9yP) derailments (http://reut.rs/1GR7Xvd), to oil (http://bit.ly/18VxY12) pipeline (http://on.wsj.com/1DVywSl) breeches (http://bit.ly/1Oy0kiG) that leak tens of thousands of gallons of crude oil into sensitive and, in the case of Yellowstone National Park, protected landscapes. And with the proposed Keystone XL Pipeline on the horizon it may be time to critically look at the advantages of solar generated power through the prism of these recent oil disasters.

Oil Train Derailments

The last five years have seen a dramatic rise of oil transported in tanker cars via rail in North America. If you wonder how dramatic, from 2009 to the last quarter of 2013, oil transported by rail has increased 28,000 percent (http://on.thestar.com/1xwgYtY). “From fewer than 10,000 carloads in 2008 to nearly half a million (http://huff.to/1C8Bgse) in 2014,” says Todd Paglia, executive director of ForestEthics. This number, by all accounts, is intended to rise in the coming years.

This means that a staggering and increasing amount of crude oil is transported along existing rail lines throughout USA and Canada. Before this boom in oil transportation by rail, there was already consensus that the tankers used for transport were unsafe and “puncture-prone (http://bit.ly/1Hz9039).” There are new safer tankers in use but those have already proved unsuccessful (http://nyti.ms/1xwhqbE) in stopping massive oil fires after a train derails.

These oil fires can be so fearsome that local firefighters opt to let some fires burn themselves out. In the case of the February 16th Mount Carbon, West Virginia, oil tanker derailment “Fire crews had little choice Tuesday but to let the tanks — each carrying up to 30,000 gallons of crude — burn themselves out (http://nypost.com/2015/02/17/fire-burns-for-hours-after-oil-train-explodes-in-west-virginia/),” reports the New York Post.

The oil tanker cars involved in the Mount Carbon train crash had been built to the new safety standards required (http://nyti.ms/1xwhqbE) by the American Association of Railroads. This did not stop the tankers from exploding.

“The sane thing to do would be to stop hauling crude oil if it can’t be transported safely. A far distant next best is to make these trains as safe as possible and require rerouting around cities and water supplies,” says Paglia. The rail companies are combatting the outraged public by lobbying to keep oil train route information secret in some parts of the U.S (http://bit.ly/1LUdl1G).

Pipeline Breeches

Transporting oil is dangerous. It's clear that transporting oil by train is potentially disastrous. But why not just through pipes? Water and waste are transported through pipes everywhere in the developed world. Why not transport oil the same way? It's gotta be safer, right?

Well, yes and no.

The potential for explosion is diminished when transporting oil through pipelines. However, the potential for damaging the environment is still relatively high. For one specific company, Bridger Pipeline, the numbers are shocking. Between 2006 and 2014, Bridger Pipeline reported (http://bit.ly/1EPfyuf) nine oil spills, and its sister company reported 21 during that same time. These combined leaks resulted in nearly 290,000 gallons of oil leaked into the environment. Both companies are operated by the same family and controlled from the same location. This company is indicative of the dangers all pipeline operators face across the world.

On January 19, in a portion of the Yellowstone National Park located in Glendive, Montana, a Bridger Pipeline leaked 50,000 gallons into the protected landscape. This pipeline breeched previously (http://alj.am/1xwiex8). It burst in 2011 and released 63,000 gallons into the same Yellowstone River.

There have been three more reported (http://bit.ly/1CnHDZV) leaks from other pipelines run by many other companies around the country since the Bridger Pipeline leak at the time of this writing.

Currently Congress is intent on pushing the Keystone XL Pipeline through legislation hurdles. Representatives claim the dozens of jobs (http://bit.ly/19NppGB) it will create will offset any concerns over environmental dangers the pipeline poses. The proposed Keystone XL Pipeline would stretch from Canada to the Gulf of Mexico.

Solar Alternative

Solar panel production is not a zero-sum game. There are still caustic chemicals (http://bit.ly/1N5Q1Rs) used during production that cause "significant occupational risk in the factory," says Dustin Mulvaney of Solar Industry Magazine. But the big difference is that those chemicals are used in producing the panels, not transporting them, which keeps the danger isolated to the production factory.

Transporting and installing solar panels does not carry the same dangers or cataclysmic devastation as oil transportation. The world is reaching a turning point in how humans generate and receive power. There is an enormous amount of money to be made by keeping fossil fuels the main source of energy generation. There will likely be much disinformation presented by the old oil guard for years to come. Look at how fracking is sold as safe (http://bit.ly/1y319Wf), as an example.

Cutting through that noise are the pictures of devastation in the heartland.

@pcdunham (https://twitter.com/pcdunham) snagged a pic from the ski cam, galena derail. pic.twitter.com/d23tUBAELz (http://t.co/d23tUBAELz)

— Matt (@mzt1504) March 5, 2015 (https://twitter.com/mzt1504/status/573621980219338752)

Galena, Illinois is a beautiful town, but the world became aware of this small 3,000-person community only after 21 of the 105 oil tanker cars derailed, five of which erupted in flames (http://nbcnews.to/1NcWSXe) so hot that local fire crews had to wait and let the fires burn out before attempting any form of cleanup.

This type of disaster doesn't happen when a shipment of solar panels gets damaged. This draws any argument about efficiency moot. Solar panels are less volatile and less damaging to our environment than oil.

See the below video to watch solar panels get abused with 200 MPH hail, baseballs, and pickup trucks to see just how durable a PV solar panel can be:

SolarWorld Sunmodule solar panels exceed internati...

Takeaway

“People’s lives are at stake, clean drinking water is at stake, and the well-being of towns and wildlife along thousands of miles of rail line are directly in harm’s way of this unchecked, reckless increase in oil transport by rail,” said (http://wapo.st/1GfGbdC) Mollie Matteson, senior scientist at the Center for Biological Diversity. Oil is a volatile substance, which perfectly fit with our combustible engines of the past century. We’ve evolved beyond that. It’s time our plans for energy generation got up to speed.

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